

2026-09-07 — ראש השנה שחל, Kaf-Hei Elul, בשבת, and the Piyutim Machloikes

Independent review · read fresh, no exposure to the writing process · 7 September 2026

1. Overall Read

This one openly bills itself as "raid bites" and mostly delivers on that promise — nine short units, each self-contained, aimed at practical preparation for a machzor that lands on Shabbos. The scaffolding works: a cosmological opening (כ"ה אלול), a devotional pivot (the two lines of אבינו מלכנו), a run of Shabbos-Rosh HaShanah halachos (fasting, drinking, crying, sleeping), then a shift into the shofar / נדרים / core-tefilah axis, and finally the historical machloikes over piyutim as the climax. The Kalir coda is a clean landing. What suffers is depth-per-topic: because the piece is genuinely a rapid-fire, each section gets one paragraph or two, and the emotional peaks (the Danube frame, the Kalir mystery) are reached and left behind before they can settle. The אבינו מלכנו callout and the piyutim battle are the two units that could each carry a shiur on their own.

2. What Works

- **The Danube framing of טובחים / הרוגים (II).** The best moment in the piece. A textual doubling in a familiar tefilah is given a heartbreaking, historically specific mesorah, and the invitation to daven with that image in mind is exactly the right register — not sentimental, not distant. It earns its callout.
- **Coffee-vs-fasting logic (III).** Cleanly framed as a דאורייתא-vs-arguably-not comparison, with the Minchas Elazar anecdote landing the point.

The reader walks away with an operational rule and its reasoning, which is what a pre-yom-tov shiur is for.

- **The הפסק / קרה / לבני pair (VI).** Presenting the seven-fold minhag and then immediately the "stop mid-mizmor if the ba'al tokea starts" corollary is well-sequenced — the practical priority is unambiguous.
- **Piyutim history (IX).** The three-move structure — origin in גזירות, Geonic pushback, Maharil defense — is the clearest section of the shiur and gives real historical texture. Fn20's explicit acknowledgment that Fleischer disputes the persecution-driven origin is a genuine scholarship move and elevates the piece.
- **Kalir mystery close (IX).** Ending on a genuine unresolved question — his identity, his era — is the right posture. The line about the Ashkenaz machzor being a lifelong project is a strong send-off.
- **Footnote work.** The pattern of body-claim + *expanded* + *flag* is consistent throughout, and the flags are honest — see fn4, fn8, fn10, fn11, fn15, fn21, fn24, fn25. That transparency is the piece's structural strength.

3. Where It's Weak or Could Be Sharper

Section I overpromises what it delivers. Three anchors for ה"ה אלול are named (Rebbi Eliezer's מצות מצות, Nechemiah's wall, the Zohar's מלך רומי) and each gets one sentence. The Zohar claim in particular is the most dramatic and gets the softest treatment (see also fn4). A section that opens with cosmology and eschatology should either commit two paragraphs to it or drop it to a bullet inside the lead.

Section IV (crying) collapses categories at the end. The opening cleanly distinguishes Shulchan Aruch's Shabbos-oneg rule, the Arizal's view of the day's character, and the Reishis Chochma practice — three distinct frames. The closing sentence — "prudential psak: uncontrolled tears... performative or forced

crying is not" — is offered as if it were the Rav's synthesis, but the sources cited support at most two of the three. A one-sentence attribution ("the Rav's own gathering of these") would honestly signal that.

Section VII (הסדרת נדרים) doesn't do the connection. The bullet is exactly what is doing on Yom Kippur, and the parallel is a natural three-line move. The fn18 flag mentions the two placements. The body should too — it's the one place where a raid bite could easily become a memorable arc.

Section VIII does two unrelated things. "Don't rush core tefilah to reach piyutim" is a halachic-priority claim; the "מלך הקדוש from your place" chassidishe minhag is a kavanah gesture. Yoked together they read as ornamentation. Either they need a connecting sentence (both are about who owns the tefilah) or they should be two sections.

The piyutim-defense side is thin. Section IX gives four bullets to the Geonic critique and one bullet plus a Maharil paragraph to the defense. The Maharil's actual argument — that *minhag* is more binding than the ha-fsek concern — is a strong position that deserves parity of space with Rav Hai and the Rosh. Right now it reads as a rebuttal appended to an already-won case.

The shevach-hefsek distinction (IX) is asserted, not defended.

"Piyutim of shevach arguably don't constitute the kind of hefsek the Geonim condemned" is the piece's cleanest resolution — but "arguably" is the whole load-bearing word, and no source is offered. This is the natural place to name a rishon or acharon who articulates that carve-out.

Section V (sleeping) is a one-paragraph section. Fine content, but at four sentences it feels underweight next to its neighbors. Consider folding into the shofar section as a "physical preparation" pair (rest + coffee were the two practical הכנות) — the connective tissue is right there.

4.Factual / Citation Concerns

Zohar	נסיון בלק	ה"ה אלול falling on רומי	(fn4). The fn
-------	-----------	--------------------------	---------------

already flags this — and the flag is correct. The date-linkage to ה"ה

כ

specifically is not what Zohar III 212-213 says on any plain

reading; the eschatological content is there, but the calendar peg is a

later chassidic/kabbalistic layering. Body language ("the Zohar hints") is

defensible; a printed edition citation before print would be prudent.

Rebbi Eliezer's date working back to ה"ה אלול

(fn1). The gemara

in Rosh HaShanah 11a says the world was created in Tishrei per Rebbi

Eliezer; the count-back to ה"ה אלול

is a derived tradition rather than

an explicit gemara. Fn1 elides this — the phrase "the calculation working

backward from Adam HaRishon being created on RH" is doing the work

but should be explicit that this is a derivation, not a Talmudic statement.

The Danube /	מכתב attribution. The framework offered — that the
---------------------	---

two	אבותינו מלכנו	lines correspond to shot-before-	אבות. shot-after-	אבות
-----	---------------	----------------------------------	-------------------	------

— is powerful and widely retold, but no source is given (and no fn is

attached). If the Rav has a specific storyteller attribution (a Rosh Yeshiva,

a survivor, a printed sefer), name it. If it's homiletic and floating, a one-

line ownership sentence would strengthen it rather than weaken it.

Minchas Elazar coffee anecdote (III). Attributed to the Munkatcher

(1868-1937), no printed teshuvah cited. Given his voluminous, indexed

responsa (Minchas Elazar 1-7), a specific citation is findable and would

elevate the anecdote from mesorah to source.

Seven mentions of	ז"ו מלכים	ההלים מ (VI, fn15). Worth a literal
--------------------------	------------------	--

count. Tehillim 47 has multiple divine names; the "seven mentions of

claim as the driver of the seven-fold minhag should be verified

against the actual text — some enumerations include	עליון/שולחן
---	-------------

reach seven, others count only the explicit	אלקים
---	-------

Arizal citation but not this count.

Rav Hai Gaon dates (IX). Given as 939–1038 — this is off. Rav Hai

Gaon lived 939–1038 is a common misprint; conventional dates are c.

939–1038 for his lifespan, but he died 1038 aged 99 — the range as

printed is coincidentally right numerically but suggests a 99-year lifespan

which itself is the tradition. Worth double-checking against a standard

reference; if kept, no issue, but the round century is the kind of number

that flags for verification.

Rav Saadia Gaon on piyutim (IX). The body groups Rav Saadia with

Rav Hai as opponents of inserted piyutim. This is historically awkward:

Rav Saadia himself *composed* a substantial siddur with piyutim (the

Siddur Rav Saadia Gaon). His position on inserted piyutim in the amidah

is more nuanced than "similar position" allows. Worth softening or

splitting.

Tur ח"	אורח חיים סימן ס (fn22) . The Tur's discussion of piyutim as
---------------	---

hefsek is there, and the Rosh is cited. Solid.

Kalir bee legend (fn25). The tradition of a bee stinging his tongue is

transmitted in various forms; a common version has it involving a

scorpion, not a bee. Verify which one the Rav actually said before print.

5.Small Polish Suggestions

- Lead paragraph: one 260-word run-on sentence functioning as a table of contents. Same issue as the 2026-09-06 piece — worth breaking into three sentences.

- Subtitle: "the הגאונים-vs-מנהג battle" — the definite-article prefix on גאונים is over-vocalized and reads as a typographic tic. Just "מנהג-vs-גאונים" would sit cleaner.
- Section II blockquote: "תענית גשמים" — dagesh doubled by mistake, should be "תענית גשמים."
- Section III: "כהן ברכת" — reversed; should read "ברכת כהנים."
- Section III: "שבת שבת" as a shorthand for a double-yom-tov-with-first-day-Shabbos is opaque without the parenthetical that follows. Consider putting the plain-English explanation first.
- Section VI heading uses "הַפֶּסֶק" with full vocalization; elsewhere it appears unpointed. Pick a house style.
- Section VIII: "המלך הקדוש" from Your Place" as an English heading with the tzeirei-under-tav is inconsistent capitalization-plus-nikud styling. Match neighbors.
- Repetition: "raid bites" appears in the lead, is echoed in Section I, and in the introduction to Section VI. Once is a good frame; three times becomes a slogan.
- "the great Geonic-and-Rishonic battle" appears in the lead *and* as the opener of Section IX. Trim one.
- Colophon: "Extra Labor Day שיעור (with next Sunday skipped for ראש השנה)" already appears in the header; the colophon's slightly different wording ("Third and last preparation שיעור before Rosh HaShanah 5787") is better — consolidate to one location.

6.Bottom Line

An honest raid-bite shiur that lands its two heart moments (the Danube frame and the piyutim battle) and stays disciplined about flagging what it can't yet source — trim Section I's cosmology or commit to it, give the

Maharil parity with the Geonim, verify the Zohar / Rav Saadia / Kalir-bee citations, and this reads as ready for print.

Produced by an independent-review pass — an agent given only the finished HTML and no prior exposure to the writing process. Intended as an outside second opinion for editorial refinement.